

How to Cover Your Budget with \$18

STARTING A CHAI CLUB FUNDRAISING PROJECT

CONTRIBUTORS

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“We introduced the Chai Club to our community in the form of a parlor meeting set in the backdrop of a wine and cheese tasting,” says Rabbi Choni Marozov of Valencia, California. “We invited fifteen couples whom we felt to be ripe for this project and presented them with our current budget, plan, and suggestions as to how much they should contribute in order to help us achieve our goal. The positive response we received from this initial parlor meeting set the precedent for a campaign that now, nine years later, takes care of more than 50 percent of our yearly budget, boruch Hashem.”

A Chai Club fundraising campaign enlists donors to spread their yearly giving throughout the course of the year in twelve monthly donations, as opposed to donating sporadically or at the end of the year.

Dispelling the Myths

MYTH: If a donor gives to us on a monthly basis, he won’t give at any other time!

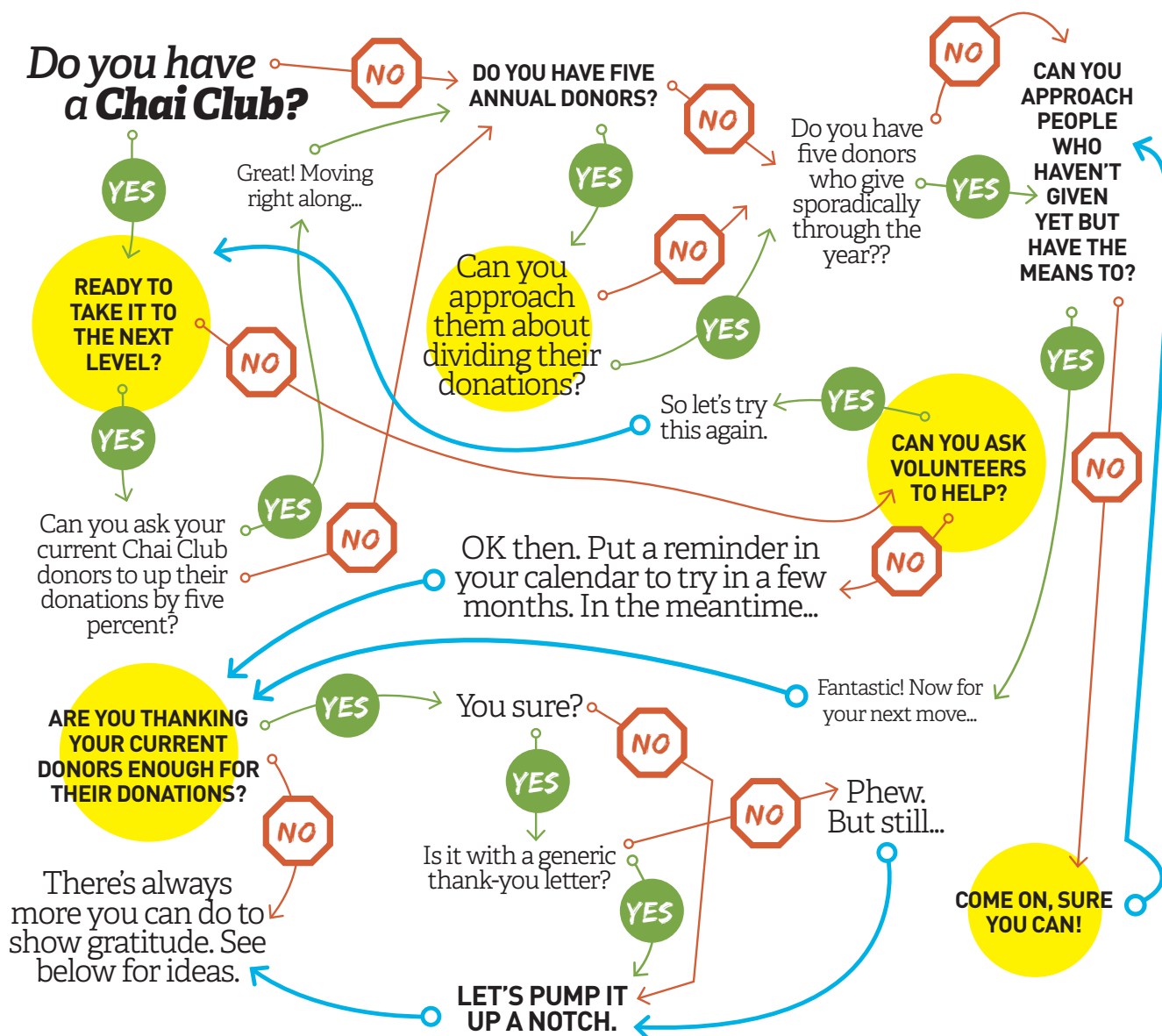
TRUTH: Donors want to give to successful organizations. They are going to be more invested.

MYTH: If I remind donors too often that they are on my monthly campaign, they will get nervous that they are supporting on such a committed level and pull their support!

TRUTH: They know! Especially the ones giving larger amounts. They didn’t get to where they are in life by overlooking the small things. Show appreciation, and they’ll continue doing it!

MYTH: It’s not worth my time getting \$18 monthly donations.

TRUTH: It sure is. With enough people signed on, it will create a critical mass.



Invitation to an annual **CHAI CLUB MEMBER EVENT** (barbeque, sushi event with speaker and annual reports, etc.)

Pre-Rosh Hashana gift of **HONEY CAKE** or apple and honey arrangement

Complimentary **LULAV AND ESROG** set

Personalized **CHANUKAH CARD** on special Chai Club stationery

Nicer **MISHLOACH MANOS**

EXTRA MATZAH before Pesach

Tickets for **FREE OR DISCOUNTED ADMISSION** to Shabbatons or other programs

DO YOUR DONORS FEEL APPRECIATED?

The right thank-you could be the thing that brings your next donation. Of course, appreciation is key for all donors—not just your Chai Club members—but **setting aside special Chai Club membership benefits creates incentive to join** and warm feelings about continuing and furthering support. Here are some suggestions.

Discounted Hebrew school **TUITION**

Gifts of personalized Chai Club **LUGGAGE TAGS** or shot glasses

Weekly “good Shabbos” **TEXT MESSAGES**

Thank-you **LETTERS OR EMAILS** every two or three months including a personalized note from the rabbi

Birthday **GIFT DELIVERY** including a bottle of wine and a personalized card

Multiple tiers within your Chai Club such as “**SUPPORTER**,” “**PILLAR**,” “**FOUNDER**,” etc., and benefits adjusted accordingly

Plus, with effort and time, you can bump those people to higher amounts.

“The shluchim we work with report that their Chai Clubs are instrumental in involving higher numbers of baalei batim as core builders of their communities,” explains Rabbi Levi Schectman of Merkos Suite 302’s Machon L’Shlichus and shliach to Wesleyan University. “Our feedback shows shluchim reaping as much as \$10,000 a month from this campaign. Plus, it also fosters a sense of working together towards a common goal, bringing light to the power and importance of tzedaka.”

Want to start a Chai Club of your own?

FIND five annual donors whom you can afford to convert to monthly donors.

FIND five people who have given randomly during the past three years and solicit them for monthly donations.

CREATE a web page where you can list names of people who are part of your Chai Club.

Take your existing Chai Club to the next level:

MAKE a list of people who have given general donations in the past and talk to them about making monthly gifts.

TALK to people who are involved in programming (but have not yet given) about becoming Chai Club members.

GO to all your monthly givers and see if you can move them up by five percent. (Obviously, this can’t be done every year, but it’s good to do from time to time.)

Not one week should go by without you thinking about whether there is someone whom you could have asked to join the Chai Club, but have not. You have to be constantly growing... otherwise, you are shrinking.

Learn from the Pros

The following tried and true tidbits can be of great use when starting up your own Chai Club:

→ Rabbi Kushi Schusterman introduced the Chai Club to his middle class community only a few months after arriving in Harford County, Maryland. “From the get go,” he says, “I set to establish the basic, and B”H ever-growing, awareness that **our Chabad House, like any organization, needs financial stability.**”

→ “**Working one on one is key** to the success of your Chai Club,” states Rabbi Uriel Vigler of the Upper West Side in New York, New York. “I set up meetings with prospective Chai Club members, letting them know in advance that I plan to ask them to participate in our program.”

→ Rabbi Choni Marozov relates: “While meeting with any prospective Chai Club member, I let him know that **joining the Chai**

Club takes him off of my solicitation list for the year. Although he will still receive periodic requests for donations along with everyone else through our mass mailings, he knows that no matter how tough things may be, I will not approach him or any other Chai Club member for additional donations throughout the year. Although this may put me in a tight spot financially, I find that our Chai Club members are more welcoming when I approach them; they know that I am not coming to them for money. Truth to be told, it is usually the Chai Club members who are the first to donate for our year round programs.”

→ “Upon approaching someone regarding the Chai Club,” says Rabbi Schusterman, “I often encounter those who state that they would prefer to give a one-time donation. While I do welcome these donations, I tell the prospective donor that from an operational standpoint, **dividing their donation, however large or small, into twelve parts will help us keep our doors open,** as it helps us maintain a steady cash flow throughout the year. People are generally quite receptive to this idea.”

→ “Once they do decide to join,” says Rabbi Vigler, “**I go to great lengths to thank them all year round, and in a personal way.**” (See “Do Your Donors Feel Appreciated?” on the previous page.) It is important to remind them that you have not forgotten about their generosity despite the fact that many months may have passed since your meeting. Publicizing the names of your Chai Club members on your Chabad House walls and website in addition to providing them with perks throughout the year will make them feel special and part of an elite group within your community.

→ Keep in mind, suggests Rabbi Schusterman, **no system is foolproof.** Credit cards will be denied, checks will not arrive, and people will back out. You have to stay on top of it and be organized. 📌



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Contact **Machon L'Shlichus** at info@machonlshlichus.com for help with your Chai Club and other fundraising questions.

For more information, check out the “**Monthly Giving Campaign**” webinar by Rabbi Eliyahu Schusterman on the Shluchim Exchange.

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